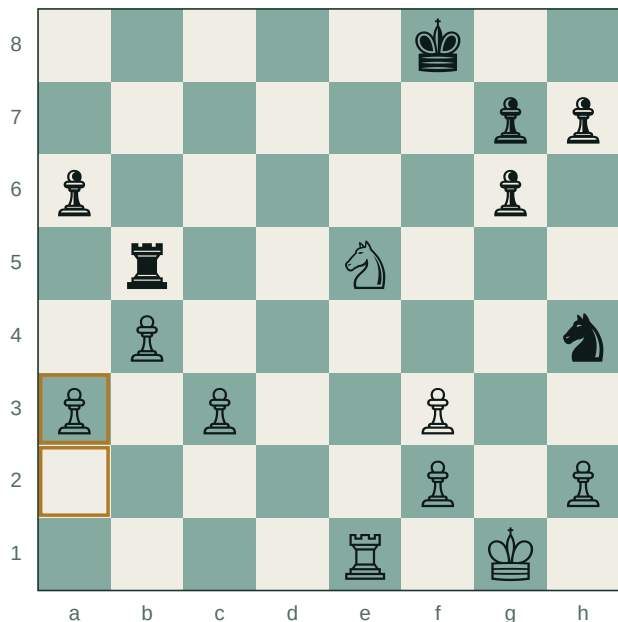


Capture the defender: Black, move 35

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 35.a3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

35...Rxe5 36. Rxe5 Nxf3+ 37. Kf1 Nxe5

35...Rxe5 The rook captures the knight on e5. Recorded reply: **36.Rxe5**.

36...Nxf3+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. From f3 it attacks king on g1 and rook on e5. Recorded reply: **37.Kf1**.

37...Nxe5 The knight captures the rook on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 5 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -2 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on e1. Check for tactical protection.